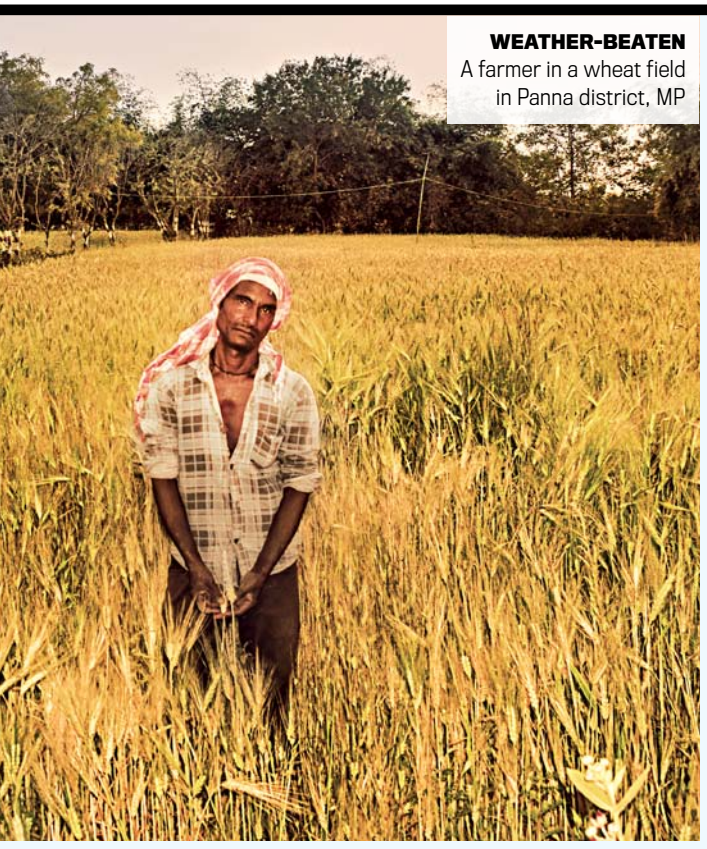
ties for just such an initiative, Salim made it clear that a 'third front' would only strengthen the BJP. "Our objective will be to align anti-BJP forces... those who were not with the BJP in the past nor would be in the future. In fact, they will have to prove their anti-BJP stand by taking part in all movements against saffron. Too much of tacit understanding is going on," says Salim.

The Left thus looks to be moving gingerly towards the role it played during the initial days of the United Progressive Alliance, seeking to unite *all* parties ranged against the BJP, regional or otherwise. In this arrangement, however, West Bengal and Kerala will need to be kept as exceptions. In Bengal, the TMC, which had unseated the Left in 2011, is very much an organic rival. In Kerala—the only state under Left rule—the Congress is the Left's main foe. Indeed, the aversion the Left has frequently exhibited vis-a-vis the Congress nationally flows directly from the half-century-long blood feud that has shaped Kerala's politics. No wonder grizzled veterans there look askance at events in the former eastern bastions. They cite the Left's gradual attenuation—the present decline in Tripura, they say, was foreshadowed by Bengal in 2021, where its yield fell to an ignominious zero. The Sagardighi win is all very well, but they fear the Left has lost its ground irrevocably in the two states, and they would be reduced to having relevance only in Kerala. ■

– with Jeemon Jacob



WEATHER-BEATEN
A farmer in a wheat field in Panna district, MP

AJAY TIWARI

we are extremely concerned, but there is little we can do. In fields where wheat sowing was later (in December) and crops are green, pod formation is taking place prematurely. The heat will eventually lead to lesser seeds in each pod, reduction in pod length and grain shrivelling, all contributing to weight loss," says Rajendra Singh Jaat, a farmer in Umraoganj village, along the river Narmada, in Raisen–one of the best wheat production districts in MP. "We can only pray to god," he adds when asked if something can be done to minimise the adverse effects of heat.

"Concerned over the persistently high temperatures, the Centre's scientists met on February 26 to chalk out a strategy for mitigating the effects of heat," says Dr G.P. Singh, director of the Karnal-based Indian Institute of Wheat and Barley Research. The agricultural scientist community is suggesting ways to reduce the impact of the heat, but there is a question mark over how much of it can be implemented. Suggestions include using mulch and irrigation to keep ground temperatures down. Jaat, however, cautions that using water while temperatures are high can also lead to excessive heat release from the ground, killing the plant (locally called *ukasnaa*) before it can complete its life cycle.

Lower production of wheat is likely to impact the plate in wheat-consuming areas. As it is, the drop in production last year led to the replacement of wheat with rice in the PDS (public distribution system) in states such as MP, UP and Gujarat where the grain is the staple crop. And in states such as Bihar and Kerala, the distribution of wheat was totally stopped and replaced with rice. Moreover, the extra central assistance under the PM Garib Kalyan Yojana has been stopped in MP since last month. While wheat stocks currently are above buffer levels, a lot depends on what the final production numbers in 2023 will be.

LOWER PRODUCTION OF WHEAT IS LIKELY TO IMPACT THE PLATE IN INDIA'S WHEAT-CONSUMING STATES

At around Rs 2,500 per quintal for the mill variety (which is the most basic), wheat is presently already almost 20 per cent costlier than its price level during February last year. Though the minimum support price (MSP) announced for 2023 is Rs 2,125, the market price is expected to be much higher. This would lead to a drop in procurement by government agencies, and potential diversion to hoarders, which will only worsen the crisis.

For consumers, a lower production will hike prices further, contributing to inflation. And on the producer side, the chances of the ban on wheat exports being lifted seem bleak in this scenario. This may deny farmers any chances of getting a higher price, which could have offset production losses.

Not all within the agricultural scientific community are pessimistic. A.K. Singh, director, Indian Agriculture Research Institute, said late last month that there was less likelihood of terminal heat conditions setting in before March 16 by when the grain-filling stage of wheat would be over. If the weather does not act whimsical, that is. ■